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User Researcher

Government Digital Service

Apply before 11:55 pm on Tuesday 5th May 2026

Government Digital Service

Reference number

457816

Salary

£42,382 - £45,653

£42,893 - £45,653 (national) Based on capability. The base salary of this grade is £42,382 (national). Offers made above this will be made up with a specialist pay allowance.

Job grade

Senior Executive Officer

Contract type

Permanent

Business area

GDS - GOV.UK

Type of role

Digital
Information Technology

Working pattern

Flexible working, Full-time, Compressed hours

Number of jobs available

3

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Location

Bristol, Manchester

About the job

Job summary

The Government Digital Service (GDS) is the digital centre of government. We are responsible for setting, leading and delivering the vision for a modern digital government.

Our priorities are to drive a modern digital government, by:

1. joining up public sector services
2. harnessing the power of AI for the public good
3. strengthening and extending our digital and data public infrastructure
4. elevating leadership and investing in talent
5. funding for outcomes and procuring for growth and innovation
6. committing to transparency and driving accountability

We are home to the Incubator for Artificial Intelligence (I.AI), the world-leading GOV.UK and at the forefront of coordinating the UK s geospatial strategy and activity. We lead the Government Digital and Data function and champion the work of digital teams across government.

We re part of the Department for Science, Innovation and Technology (DSIT) and employ more than 1,000 people all over the UK, with hubs in Manchester, London and Bristol.

The Government Digital Service is where talent translates into impact. From your first day, you ll be working with some of the world s most highly-skilled digital professionals, all contributing their knowledge to make change on a national scale.

Join us for rewarding work that makes a difference across the UK. You'll solve some of the nation s highest-priority digital challenges, helping millions of people access services they need

Job description

We are hiring three User Researchers, two for GOV.UK and one for GOV.UK Chat.

GOV.UK is the trusted online home for government information and services. Every week millions of people rely on it to complete essential and often life-changing tasks. GOV.UK also supports government colleagues to publish content, ensuring accurate and accessible information is always available to the public.

GOV.UK Chat is our AI-powered chatbot that allows users, for the first time, to get quick, personalised answers to their questions based on GOV.UK guidance.

As a User Researcher, you will:

- make an impact: work on and tackle challenges in public infrastructure, improving lives through solutions that are informed by high quality, evidence-based, insights
- deliver work that matters: driving change, delivering better value and outcomes for users and government, to empower and transform
- grow with us: thrive in a supportive research community that values experimentation, learning, failing fast and reflection as key steps to growth. With dedicated development resources, training and cross-government networks, you will have plenty of opportunities to grow

Your main responsibilities are:

- plan and conduct a wide range of user research projects that are aligned with your teams vision and goals
- deliver high-quality, end-to-end research: from planning, research design, and participant recruitment to analysis and actionable reporting
- design and execute user research that drives the development and continuous improvement of government products/services, ensuring insights lead to informed decision-making
- collaborate with multidisciplinary teams and stakeholders throughout the research process, working closely with product managers, designers, and

developers to transform user insights into impactful product and service features

advocate for the user by maintaining a clear focus on their needs and behaviours, while also understanding wider business goals - bringing both perspectives together to deliver impactful research that fosters empathy and supports informed, balanced decision-making

clearly and effectively communicate user research insights to teams, fostering a shared and deep understanding of research learnings

be a reflective practitioner - consistently explore and implement innovative ways to deliver better outcomes, whether by refining existing methods/ practices or experimenting with new, creative approaches

manage time effectively to deliver high-quality research on time, while sharing ideas and learnings to support team growth and contribute to research libraries and reusable knowledge - helping to shape the future of the research community through collaboration

Person specification

You don't need government experience to apply for this role. We re looking for User Researchers for GOV.UK and GOV.UK Chat with experience in applying a range of research methods and approaches. You ll be a good communicator with a proven track record of advocating for users, delivering impactful research insights that drive informed decision-making.

We re interested in people who can demonstrate:

experience and understanding of established user research methods, including those related with planning, analysis, and sharing of findings - to generate insights that inform inclusive, human-centred design, grounded in an understanding of user behaviour and psychology

ability to present clear insights that colleagues can understand and use, through clear, compelling storytelling

experience collaborating with multidisciplinary teams, actively engaging colleagues in research activities

ability to include all kinds of users in appropriate research activities to help teams understand the diversity of users of government services

understanding of social and technological contexts and their influence on user behavior and solutions. Knowledgeable in user-centered design, accessibility, and inclusion practices

initiative and a proactive mindset by seeking creative and collaborative solutions - whether working independently or with support on complex projects - and consistently reflects on practice to drive improvement and deliver meaningful change

experience of conducting research in the context of an AI Chat Bot (desirable, not essential for the GOV.UK Chat role)

Benefits

There are many benefits of working at GDS, including:

flexible hybrid working with flexi-time and the option to work part-time or condensed hours

a Civil Service Pension with an average employer contribution of 28.97%

25 days of annual leave, increasing by a day each year up to a maximum of 30 days

an extra day off for the King s birthday

an in-year bonus scheme to recognise high performance

career progression and coaching, including a training budget for personal development

a focus on wellbeing with access to an employee assistance programme

job satisfaction from making government services easier to use and more inclusive for people across the UK

advances on pay, including for travel season tickets

death in service benefits

cycle to work scheme and facilities

access to an employee discounts scheme

10 learning days per year

volunteering opportunities (5 special leave days per year)

access to a suite of learning activities through Civil Service learning

Any move to Government Digital Service from another employer will mean you can no longer access childcare vouchers. This includes moves between government departments. You may however be eligible for other government schemes, including Tax Free Childcare. Determine your eligibility at https://www.childcarechoices.gov.uk

Office attendance
The Department operates a discretionary hybrid working policy, which provides for a combination of working hours from your place of work and from your home in the UK. The current expectation for staff is to attend the office or non-home based location for 40-60% of the time over the accounting period.
DSIT does not normally offer full home working (i.e. working at home); but we do offer a variety of flexible working options (including occasionally working from home).

Things you need to know

Artificial intelligence

Artificial intelligence can be a useful tool to support your application, however, all examples and statements provided must be truthful, factually accurate and taken directly from your own experience. Where plagiarism has been identified (presenting the ideas and experiences of others, or generated by artificial intelligence, as your own) applications may be withdrawn and internal candidates may be subject to disciplinary action. Please see our candidate guidance (opens in a new window) for more information on appropriate and inappropriate use.

Selection process details

The standard selection process for roles at GDS consists of:

application stage: you ll be asked to submit a CV and cover letter of up to 750 words, demonstrating your previous work history, that should meet the skills and experience listed in the person specification above. Failure to submit your CV and complete the application questions will result in your application being unsuccessful

panel interview stage: 75 minute video interview, We will use this to understand your work, experience, and assess in terms of competency and behaviours. You will receive a brief beforehand if preparation is needed. This will be conducted over video conferencing

technical exercise stage: 120 minute video interview. This is a research technical exercise session. In this session, we will assess your research practices and skills using a series of practical tasks. You will receive a brief with more info about this before attending the exercise session. This will be conducted over video conferencing

Depending on how many applications we get, there might also be an extra stage before the video interview, for example a phone interview or a technical exercise.

In the event we receive a high volume of applications, we will conduct the initial sift against the lead criteria which is:

experience and understanding of established user research methods, including those related with planning, analysis, and sharing findings - to generate insights that inform inclusive, human-centred design, grounded in an understanding of user behaviour and psychology

In the Civil Service, we use Success Profiles to evaluate your skills and ability. This gives us the best possible chance of finding the right person for the job, increases performance and improves diversity and inclusivity. We ll be assessing your technical abilities, skills, experience and behaviours that are relevant to this role.

For this role we ll be assessing you against the following Civil Service Behaviours:

seeing the big picture

changing and Improving

communicating and influencing

working together

delivering at pace

We ll also be assessing your experience and specialist technical skills against the following skills defined in the Government Digital and Data Capability Framework for the User Researcher role:

- agile research practices
- analysis and synthesis
- inclusive research
- research management, leadership and assurance
- stakeholder relationship management
- user research methods
- user-centred practice and advocacy

Want to know more about who Government Digital and Data are? Click Here

Recruitment Timeline

Sift completion: 15th May 2026

Interviews:

- panel w/c 18th May 2026
- technical exercise 28th May 2026

Candidates that do not pass the interview but have demonstrated an acceptable standard may be considered for similar roles at a lower grade.

A reserve list will be held for a period of 12 months, from which further appointments can be made.

The Civil Service is committed to attract, retain and invest in talent wherever it is found. To learn more please see the Civil Service People Plan and the Civil Service D&I Strategy.

Sponsorship

DSIT cannot offer Visa sponsorship to candidates through this campaign. DSIT holds a Visa sponsorship licence but this can only be used for certain roles and this campaign does not qualify.

Location

Whilst this role's location is Bristol / Manchester, if you are a current Civil servant working in DSIT and based in London, you are also able to apply for this role. If you are successful, you will retain your London location and pay.

Security

Counter Terrorist Check (CTC) red stripe on pass: CTC is required if an individual is working in proximity to public figures, or requires unescorted access to buildings assessed to be at particular risk from terrorist attacks (certain military, civil, industrial or commercial establishments and all Whitehall buildings).

To gain CTC clearance, applicants will usually need to have been a UK resident for a minimum of 3 years. In addition to the checks performed as part of BPSS CTC will also involve checks to prevent persons who may have connections with terrorist organisations, or who may be vulnerable to pressure from them, from undertaking certain security duties where sensitive information may be compromised. CTC normally takes 4 - 6 weeks

Feedback will only be provided if you attend an interview or assessment.

Security

Successful candidates must undergo a criminal record check.

Successful candidates must meet the security requirements before they can be appointed. The level of security needed is counter-terrorist check (opens in a new window).

See our vetting charter (opens in a new window).

People working with government assets must complete baseline personnel security standard (opens in new window) checks.

Nationality requirements

This job is broadly open to the following groups:

- UK nationals
- nationals of the Republic of Ireland
- nationals of Commonwealth countries who have the right to work in the UK
- nationals of the EU, Switzerland, Norway, Iceland or Liechtenstein and family members of those nationalities with settled or pre-settled status under the European Union Settlement Scheme (EUSS) (opens in a new window)
- nationals of the EU, Switzerland, Norway, Iceland or Liechtenstein and family members of those nationalities who have made a valid application for settled or pre-settled status under the European Union Settlement Scheme (EUSS)
- individuals with limited leave to remain or indefinite leave to remain who were eligible to apply for EUSS on or before 31 December 2020
- Turkish nationals, and certain family members of Turkish nationals, who have accrued the right to work in the Civil Service

Further information on nationality requirements (opens in a new window)

Working for the Civil Service

The Civil Service Code (opens in a new window) sets out the standards of behaviour expected of civil servants.

We recruit by merit on the basis of fair and open competition, as outlined in the Civil Service Commission's recruitment principles (opens in a new window).

The Civil Service embraces diversity and promotes equal opportunities. As such, we run a Disability Confident Scheme (DCS) for candidates with disabilities who meet the minimum selection criteria.

Diversity and Inclusion

The Civil Service is committed to attract, retain and invest in talent wherever it is found. To learn more please see the Civil Service People Plan (opens in a new window) and the Civil Service Diversity and Inclusion Strategy (opens in a new window).

Apply and further information

This vacancy is part of the Great Place to Work for Veterans (opens in a new window) initiative.

The Civil Service welcomes applications from people who have recently left prison or have an unspent conviction. Read more about prison leaver recruitment (opens in new window).

Once this job has closed, the job advert will no longer be available. You may want to save a copy for your records.

Contact point for applicants

Job contact :

Name : gdsrecruitment@dsit.gov.uk

Email : gdsrecruitment@dsit.gov.uk

Recruitment team

Email : gdsrecruitment@dsit.gov.uk

Further information

If you feel your application has not been treated in accordance with the Recruitment Principles and you wish to make a complaint, you should contact gds-complaints@dsit.gov.uk in the first instance.

If you are not satisfied with the response you receive you can contact the Civil Service Commission by email: info@csc.gov.uk Or in writing: Civil Service Commission, Room G/8 1 Horse Guards Road, London, SW1A 2HQ.

Civil Service Commission

disability confident EMPLOYER